The Lake Isle of Innisfree

The big idea

W. B. Yeats, the Irish poet, standing on the grey pavements of a city (London), longs to escape to **Innisfree**, a small island in Lough Gill, Ireland. He imagines a simple life close to nature where he will find **peace**. The poem expresses **longing for peace and natural beauty** amid city life.

Summary

- **Stanza 1**: He will arise and go to Innisfree and build a **small cabin of clay and wattles**. He will grow **nine bean-rows**, keep a **hive for the honey-bee**, and **live alone in the bee-loud glade**.
- **Stanza 2**: There he will have **peace**, which comes "dropping slow" from the veils of morning to where the cricket sings. **Midnight's all a glimmer, noon a purple glow, and evening full of the linnet's wings.**
- **Stanza 3**: He will go, because night and day he hears **lake water lapping with low sounds** by the shore. Even while standing on the roadway or on the **pavements grey**, he hears it in the **deep heart's core**.

CONTRAST

City: grey pavements, roadway, restlessness. **Innisfree**: colours, bees, crickets, linnets, lapping water, peace.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Imagery	"bee-loud glade", "noon a purple glow", "linnet's wings"
Alliteration	"**l**ake water **l**apping with **l**ow sounds"; "**p**avements **g**rey"
Repetition	"I will arise and go now"
Metaphor	"veils of the morning" (mist); peace "dropping slow"
Onomatopoeia	"lapping"
Inversion	"And a small cabin build there"

FORM

Three quatrains, rhyme scheme **ABAB**. Long, slow lines create a calm, musical mood.

Themes

- **Escape from city life** to nature.
- **Peace of mind** through simplicity and solitude.
- **Nostalgia**: Innisfree was a place of Yeats's childhood memories.

"WATTLES"

Wattles are interlaced sticks used with clay to make walls. They are not a kind of tree or fruit.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What kind of place is Innisfree? What three things will the poet do there? What does he hear in his "deep heart's core"? Pick out images of sight and sound.

Quick recap

- Poet longs for Innisfree: cabin, nine bean-rows, beehive.
- Peace at all times of day; lake water lapping.
- ABAB; strong imagery and alliteration.

Practice questions

1. The poem "The Lake Isle of Innisfree" was written by
   (a) William Wordsworth (b) Robert Frost (c) W. B. Yeats (d) Coates Kinney
2. What will the poet build at Innisfree?
   (a) A small cabin of clay and wattles (b) A large stone house (c) A boat (d) A temple
3. How many bean-rows does the poet want to grow?
   (a) Seven (b) Nine (c) Ten (d) Twelve
4. "Bee-loud glade" refers to
   (a) a noisy city street (b) a crowded market (c) an open space in the woods buzzing with bees (d) a beehive
5. Where is the poet standing when he hears the lake water?
   (a) On the shore of the lake (b) In his cabin (c) On the roadway or grey pavements (d) On a boat
6. "Lake water lapping with low sounds" is an example of
   (a) simile (b) personification (c) alliteration (d) irony
7. Describe the poet's idea of peace in Innisfree.

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. b 4. c 5. c 6. c 7. see notes